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U.S. Economics News:

- **Labor Market:** Private payrolls fell 86,000 in February, missing expectations of a 60,000 gain, while January's strong 172,000 gain was revised down.[3]
- **Economic Outlook:** The economy expanded 2.2% in 2025 and appears to be starting 2026 at a similar tepid pace. While concerns persist around elevated government spending since COVID, inflation remaining above the Fed's 2% target, and overvalued stocks, positive factors include continued technological innovation and spreading AI adoption potentially boosting productivity.[3]
- **Corporate Earnings:** S&P 500 earnings growth reached 14.2% year-over-year in Q4 2025, marking the fifth consecutive quarter of double-digit growth. All eleven sectors reported positive earnings growth, led by Information Technology (33.4%), Industrials (26.7%), and Communication Services (13.1%).[3]
- **Services Sector:** The ISM Non-Manufacturing index jumped to 56.1 in February, beating expectations and reaching its highest level since July 2022. Fourteen of eighteen service industries reported growth, with business activity climbing to 59.9 and new orders surging to 58.6.[3]
- **Consumer Debt:** U.S. household debt reached $18.78 trillion in Q4 2025, up $740 billion for the year. Mortgage balances comprise 70% of total debt at $13.17 trillion, with 92.7% being fixed-rate loans averaging 4.4% interest. Aggregate delinquency rates rose to 4.8%, the highest since late 2019, driven primarily by student loan delinquencies climbing to 16.4% as pandemic-era forbearance programs have ended.[3]
- **Retail Sales:** Retail sales fell 0.2% in January, slightly better than the expected 0.3% decline, as severe winter weather disrupted consumer activity. Health and personal care stores saw the largest drop (3.0%) since COVID lockdowns, while gasoline stations declined 2.9%.[3]
- **Fixed Income:** The 10-year Treasury yield stood at 3.94% at end-February, down 27 basis points from a year earlier, as surging geopolitical risk and elevated equity valuations drove investors to haven assets. Gold prices surged 22.2% year-to-date to $5,171.74 per troy ounce despite pulling back from January's record high of $5,417.21.[3]
- **Energy Markets:** Crude oil prices surged 16.72% year-to-date through February, driven by escalating U.S.-Iran conflict and threats to Middle Eastern shipping routes. The Strait of Hormuz, which typically handles 13 million barrels daily (31% of seaborne crude flows), saw traffic plummet from 104 ships on February 27 to just three on March 3. Economists note that while Americans will pay more for energy, domestic producers will earn higher incomes and expand production, potentially offsetting recessionary concerns.[3]

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Digital Assets News:

- **Coinbase Expansion:** Coinbase launched stock and ETF trading capabilities for all U.S. users, marking a strategic pivot beyond its cryptocurrency roots. This expansion aligns with the company's ambitious "everything exchange" vision to become a comprehensive financial platform offering traditional securities alongside digital assets, positioning itself to compete directly with established brokerages like Robinhood and traditional investment platforms.[5]
- **Kraken Secures Federal Reserve Access:** Cryptocurrency exchange Kraken achieved a significant regulatory milestone by gaining direct access to the Federal Reserve's payment infrastructure, enabling the platform to process transactions through the U.S. central banking system. This integration allows Kraken to offer more seamless fiat currency transfers, faster settlement times, and enhanced banking services, positioning the exchange as a bridge between traditional finance and digital assets.[5]
- **Market Resilience:** Bitcoin has demonstrated remarkable strength throughout the Iran conflict, outpacing traditional safe-haven assets like gold and silver while also surpassing equity market returns. This counterintuitive performance during geopolitical turbulence has significantly dampened previously prevailing bearish sentiment among traders and analysts, suggesting the cryptocurrency's maturation as a distinct asset class with unique risk-reward characteristics during crisis periods.[5]
- **U.S. Clarity Act:** Senate negotiations on comprehensive crypto market structure legislation remain stalled as lawmakers grapple with fundamental disagreements over regulatory jurisdiction between the SEC and CFTC, the definition of which digital assets qualify as securities versus commodities, and appropriate consumer protection frameworks. Bipartisan support exists in principle, but bridging these institutional and ideological divides has proven challenging, leaving the bill's timeline uncertain.[5]
- **Fear Index:** The Crypto Fear and Greed Index remained persistently bearish throughout February and March, fluctuating predominantly between "fear" (25-45) and "extreme fear" (0-24) territory. This prolonged period of negative sentiment reflected ongoing market uncertainty, diminished investor confidence, and risk-averse positioning across the cryptocurrency sector, with only brief intermittent spikes toward neutral levels before retreating back into fear zones.[5]

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Geopolitics News:

- **China:** Beijing begins its "Two Sessions" political meetings to unveil its 15th Five-Year Plan and annual growth targets amid concerns over sluggish consumption and demographic challenges. Analysts fear the roadmap won't substantially depart from President Xi Jinping's current policies.[1]
- **China:** The government ordered top refiners to suspend diesel and gasoline exports immediately as Iran war disrupts crude oil supplies from the Middle East. Qatar Energy declared force majeure on LNG shipments after production facility attacks.[1]
- **Europe:** EU unveiled Industrial Accelerator Act marking drastic shift from free trade doctrine, aiming to increase manufacturing from 14.3% to 20% of economy by 2035. Targets Chinese competition amid fears 600,000 automotive jobs could disappear.[1]
- **France:** Deployed Rafale fighter jets over UAE to protect military bases after Iranian drone hit hangar at French facility. France maintains hundreds of personnel and aircraft stationed at Dhafra base near Abu Dhabi.[1]
- **France:** President Macron announced expansion of nuclear arsenal and extension of deterrent coverage to eight European countries including UK, Germany, and Poland. New nuclear-armed submarine "The Invincible" launching in 2036 amid increasingly unstable strategic environment.[1]
- **India:** Trump administration granted India limited 30-day waiver to buy sanctioned Russian oil currently stranded at sea as Iran war cut off Persian Gulf supplies. India imports 90% of fuel, with few alternatives available.[1]
- **Iran:** US submarine sank Iranian frigate IRIS Dena off Sri Lanka killing at least 80, dramatically widening Washington's naval campaign. Defense Secretary Hegseth said vessel thought safe in international waters was torpedoed while returning from India.[1]
- **Iran:** Assembly of Experts selected Mojtaba Khamenei as new Supreme Leader following father's assassination. Trump demanded approval over selection, saying anyone without US consent "won't last long.."[1]
- **Lebanon:** Government took unprecedented step outlawing Hezbollah's military activities after group launched missiles at Israel for second consecutive day. Pro-Hezbollah newspaper condemned move as potentially sparking civil war amid ongoing divisions.[1]
- **US:** Treasury Secretary Bessent considering raising Chinese oil purchase reductions from Russia/Iran in Paris talks with Vice Premier He. Seeks expanded soybean/Boeing purchases and rare-earth export relaxations ahead of Trump-Xi summit.[1]

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The Good News:

- **Fusion Breakthrough:** New Zealand startup OpenStar Technologies successfully levitated a half-tonne magnet in superheated plasma exceeding one million degrees Celsius, marking a significant step toward replicating the sun's power. The Wellington-based company demonstrated the achievement before Prime Minister Christopher Luxon, advancing the quest for sustained nuclear fusion energy.[2]
- **Satellite Connectivity:** SpaceX's Starlink will partner with Deutsche Telekom to launch satellite-based mobile service across 10 European countries by 2028, using second-generation V2 satellites. The service will provide communications in remote areas where traditional network expansion faces challenges from conservation requirements or difficult terrain, marking Starlink's first European V2 deployment.[2]
- **Affordable Lidar:** MicroVision has designed solid-state automotive lidar sensors priced below $200, less than half current costs, with a long-term goal of $100 per unit. This breakthrough could make lidar technology accessible for mainstream advanced driver-assistance systems rather than limiting it to expensive autonomous vehicle programs, addressing the primary barrier of cost.[2]
- **Addiction Prevention:** GLP-1 weight loss drugs reduced substance use disorder risk by 14-25% across alcohol, cannabis, cocaine, nicotine, and opioids in a study of 606,434 US veterans. For those already using substances, the medications cut overdose risk by 39%, emergency visits by 31%, and mortality by 50%, working through brain reward pathways.[2]
- **Flexible Dosing:** A study of 34 patients found most maintained weight loss and health benefits like reduced blood pressure when spacing GLP-1 injections to every 2-3 weeks instead of weekly. Only four patients regained weight and quickly resumed weekly shots, offering a more sustainable option for those concerned about lifelong weekly injections.[2]

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Dividend Portfolio News:

- **A:** Agilent to acquire Biocare Medical for $950M, expanding its pathology portfolio and strengthening capabilities in anatomical pathology diagnostics and cancer detection solutions.[4]
- **CAT:** Dow plunged 1,200 points amid Middle East conflict escalation and oil price surges, with industrial stocks like Caterpillar facing headwinds from market volatility and inflation concerns.[4]
- **LMT:** Defense contractors meeting with White House on weapons production acceleration; Trump administration pushing for quadrupled munitions output as Middle East tensions escalate and stockpiles face pressure.[4]
- **PCAR:** Class 8 trucking recovery accelerated in February, signaling improved heavy-duty truck demand trends benefiting manufacturers like PACCAR in commercial vehicle segment.[4]
- **VLO:** Valero priced $850M senior notes due 2036; oil crossed $90/barrel amid Middle East war escalation, benefiting refiners; Trump administration considering options to manage surging energy prices.[4]

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Growth Portfolio News

- **EIX:** Highlighted as energy bargain trading below 10x earnings amid US-Iran war lifting crude prices.[4]
- **NVDA:** Texas Instruments (TXN) is combining its real-time control, sensing, and power portfolio tools with Nvidia's (NVDA) advanced robotics computing, ethernet-based sensing, and simulation technologies to help developers build and deploy humanoid robots. And, Lumentum (LITE) has strengthened its position as a strategic partner in providing critical laser supply following Nvidia's (NVDA) substantial investment in the company.[4]
- **SUPV:** Outlined 25%-30% loan growth target for 2026 as margins recover and capital strengthens during earnings call.[4]

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Summary:

In regard to the United States Economy, private payrolls unexpectedly fell in February amid temporary factors like severe weather and labor strikes, though economists suggest recent months together show modest underlying gains. Corporate earnings remained robust with the S&P 500 posting its fifth consecutive quarter of double-digit growth at fourteen-point-two percent. However, retail sales declined and household debt reached record levels with rising delinquency rates as pandemic-era forbearance programs ended.

In the world of digital assets, Coinbase launched stock and ETF trading capabilities marking its strategic expansion into traditional securities, while Kraken achieved direct Federal Reserve payment infrastructure access enabling seamless fiat transfers. Bitcoin demonstrated remarkable resilience during the Iran conflict, outpacing traditional safe havens and equities despite persistent bearish sentiment. Senate negotiations on comprehensive crypto legislation remain stalled over disagreements regarding regulatory jurisdiction between SEC and CFTC.

Recently around the globe, the Middle East conflict intensified with U.S. submarine operations sinking Iranian vessels and crude oil prices surging as Strait of Hormuz shipping traffic plummeted dramatically. China ordered refiners to suspend fuel exports amid supply disruptions while unveiling industrial policy shifts targeting manufacturing expansion. France expanded nuclear deterrence coverage to eight European countries and deployed fighters to protect UAE bases, while India received temporary sanctions waivers to purchase Russian oil.

For the good news, New Zealand startup OpenStar successfully levitated magnets in million-degree plasma advancing fusion energy development, while SpaceX's Starlink partnered with Deutsche Telekom for European satellite mobile service. MicroVision designed automotive lidar sensors under two hundred dollars making advanced driver assistance technology accessible for mainstream vehicles. GLP-1 weight loss medications demonstrated powerful addiction prevention benefits reducing substance use disorder risk by fourteen to twenty-five percent across multiple drugs.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, defense contractors met with White House officials to accelerate weapons production amid escalating Middle East tensions benefiting companies like Lockheed Martin. Valero priced senior notes as oil crossed ninety dollars per barrel during conflict escalation, while Class 8 trucking recovery accelerated signaling improved commercial vehicle demand. Agilent announced a nine-hundred-fifty-million-dollar acquisition of Biocare Medical expanding its pathology diagnostics capabilities.

And, for the growth portfolio, Nvidia and Texas Instruments have begun a partnership in developing humanoid robots. Edison International emerged as energy bargain trading below ten-times earnings, while SUPV outlined twenty-five to thirty percent loan growth targets.

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